

干炒鸡河 gàn chǎo jī hé

Chicken Chow Fun

When ordering noodles at Sunday dim sum brunches, we (along with aunts, uncles, and cousins) reliably split into two factions: team flat noodle vs. team fried noodle. This dish is a prime example of something team flat noodle might lobby for: slippery, chewy wide rice noodles cooked “dry” (without a gravy-like sauce), with plenty of wok hei. The classic beef version is called gon chow gnau ho and is one of the most popular recipes on our blog, but for those who prefer chicken, this chow fun is a tasty alternative. Smoky wok hei is crucial to this dish; to get it, crank up the heat as high as possible to preheat your wok until smoking, and then add the oil. This creates a nonstick effect on the surface of your wok (see page 23).

Serves 4

FOR VELVETING THE CHICKEN

8 ounces boneless, skinless chicken breast, thinly sliced against the grain

1 tablespoon water

1 teaspoon cornstarch

1 teaspoon neutral oil

2 teaspoons oyster sauce

½ teaspoon light soy sauce

FOR THE SAUCE

1 tablespoon oyster sauce

1 tablespoon light soy sauce

2 teaspoons dark soy sauce

½ teaspoon MSG (optional)

½ teaspoon sugar

½ teaspoon toasted sesame oil

¼ teaspoon white pepper powder

FOR THE REST OF THE DISH

1 pound fresh wide rice noodles, either pre-cut or in sheets, or 8 ounces dried wide rice noodles

3 tablespoons neutral oil, plus 1 teaspoon if using dried noodles

3 (⅛-inch-thick) slices fresh ginger

1 medium garlic clove, chopped

4 scallions, white and green parts separated, halved lengthwise, and cut into 3-inch pieces

2 tablespoons Shaoxing wine

6 ounces fresh mung bean sprouts

VELVET THE CHICKEN: Combine the chicken, water, cornstarch, neutral oil, oyster sauce, and light soy sauce. Use your hands to massage the chicken until it has absorbed the marinade. Marinate at room temperature for 30 minutes.

MAKE THE SAUCE: In a small bowl, combine the oyster sauce, light soy sauce, dark soy sauce, MSG (if using), sugar, sesame oil, and white pepper.

COOK THE NOODLES: If you have the noodles that came in sheets, slice them so they're about 1 inch wide. (Cut them right before cooking so they don't have a chance to stick together.) If using dried noodles, boil them according to package instructions, or until al dente. Rinse with cool water, drain, and toss with 1 teaspoon of the neutral oil.

ASSEMBLE THE DISH: Heat a wok over high heat until smoking. Then add 1½ tablespoons of the neutral oil to coat. Add the chicken in one layer and sear for 1 minute on each side, until lightly browned around the edges and about 90 percent done. Remove from the wok and set aside.

With the wok still on high heat, add the remaining 1½ tablespoons oil. Add the ginger, garlic, and the white parts of the scallions. Cook for 15 to 20 seconds, until fragrant. Spread the rice noodles evenly in the wok and stir-fry for about 15 seconds. Add the Shaoxing wine around the perimeter of the wok.

Next, add the sauce and the seared chicken. Stir-fry everything together for 2 to 3 minutes, until the noodles are heated through. Use your wok spatula to scrape the bottom of the wok to prevent sticking and lift the noodles in an upward motion to coat them evenly with the sauce.



Add the bean sprouts and green parts of the scallions. Stir-fry for 1 minute, until the bean sprouts and the scallions are just wilted. Serve immediately.

TIP! Some refrigerated fresh rice noodles can be very stiff and stuck together, even after slicing. If that's the case, you'll need to dip the noodles in hot or boiling water to soften them up right before adding them to the wok to stir-fry.